Once personal identities and entire social systems are built on top of a story, it becomes unthinkable to doubt it, not because of the evidence supporting it, but because its collapse will trigger a personal and social cataclysm. In history, the roof is sometimes more important than the foundations.

Hocus pocus and the industry of belief

The stories that provide us with meaning and identity are all fictional, but humans need to believe in them. So how to make the story *feel* real? It's obvious *why* humans want to believe the story, but *how* do they actually believe? Already thousands of years ago priests and shamans discovered the answer: rituals. A ritual is a magical act that makes the abstract concrete and the fictional real. The essence of ritual is the magical spell 'Hocus pocus, X is Y!'[5]

How to make Christ real to his devotees? In the ceremony of Mass, the priest takes a piece of bread and a glass of wine, and proclaims that the bread is Christ's flesh, the wine is Christ's blood, and by eating and drinking them the faithful attain communion with Christ. What could be more real than actually tasting Christ in your mouth? Traditionally, the priest made these bold proclamations in Latin, the ancient language of religion, law, and the secrets of life. In front of the amazed eyes of the assembled peasants the priest held high a piece of bread and exclaimed '*Hoc est corpus!*'– 'This is the body!' – and the bread supposedly became the flesh of Christ. In the minds of the illiterate peasants, who did not speak Latin, '*Hoc est corpus!*' got garbled into 'Hocus pocus!' and thus was born the powerful spell that can transform a frog into a prince, and a pumpkin into a carriage.[6]

A thousand years before the birth of Christianity, the ancient Hindus used the same trick. The *Brihadaranyaka Upanishad* interprets the ritual sacrifice of a horse as a realisation of the entire story of the cosmos. The text follows the 'Hocus pocus, X is Y!' structure, saying that: 'The head of the sacrificial horse is the dawn, its eye the sun, its vital force the air, its open mouth the fire called Vaisvanara, and the body of the sacrificial horse is the year … its members are the seasons, its joints the months and fortnights, its feet the days and nights, its bones the stars, and its flesh the clouds … its yawning is lightning, its shaking the body is thundering, its making water is raining, and its neighing is voice.'[7]

Almost anything can be turned into a ritual, by giving mundane gestures like lighting candles, ringing bells or counting beads a deep religious meaning. The same is true of physical gesticulations, such as bowing the